



THE INVESTOR'S MENU, EXPLAINED

Where to Put Your Money

You know why to invest. Now the where: cash, bonds, stocks, funds, property and gold — what each really is, what it's good for, and how to combine them into a sensible plan you can actually follow.

A PLAIN TOUR OF EVERY OPTION · FOUR PARTS · ELEVEN CHAPTERS · BUILDS
ON BOOK ONE

Where to Put Your Money. Book Two of *Money, Mastered — The Roadmap*. First Edition · 2026. It assumes only what Book One (*Money, From Zero*) taught — money, inflation, compounding, risk and diversification — and needs nothing more.

A note on currency. Like Book One, this is for a global reader and uses the dollar sign \$ simply as a stand-in for *your* currency. Every idea is universal; only the symbol changes.

Education, not advice. This book explains the main kinds of investment in plain terms; it is not personalised financial advice and recommends no specific product, fund or security. Names, where they appear, are illustrative examples only. Figures are rounded and illustrative.

Set in Fraunces, Spectral & Archivo. Diagrams are original vector graphics; photographs are used under free licences and embedded so the book works offline.

ONE HONEST WARNING

Every investment in this book can lose money. Higher potential returns always come bundled with higher risk — there is no safe, high, guaranteed return anywhere. Anyone who tells you otherwise is mistaken or lying. This book will help you choose risk wisely and spread it sensibly; it cannot make risk disappear, and neither can anyone else.

THE ROADMAP

Where This Book Sits

Book One taught you why to invest. This is Book Two — the tour of where. After it, the roadmap turns toward the markets themselves.

STAGE 1 · FOUNDATIONS

Book 1 · Money, From Zero

DONE

Book 2 · Where to Put Your Money**YOU ARE HERE**

STAGE 2 · THE MARKETS

Book 3 · How the Market Works

ALREADY WRITTEN

Book 4 · Fundamental Analysis

JUDGING A BUSINESS

Book 5 · Technical Analysis

READING CHARTS

Book 6 · Funds, SIPs & Portfolios

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Book 7 · Derivatives, Tax, Psychology & Safety

ADVANCED & PROTECTION

STAGE 3 · WEALTH

Book 8 · Building & Protecting Wealth

THE LONG GAME

If you haven't read Book One, start there — this book assumes you know what money, inflation, compounding and risk are. With that foundation, everything here will feel easy.

CONTENTS · BOOK TWO

What's Inside

Eleven chapters in four parts. We start with the lens to judge *any* investment, tour the menu from the safe end to the growth end, then show how to combine the options into a plan that fits your goals.

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WELCOME

How to Use This Book

“I want to invest — but in what?” This book answers that question completely, walking you down the menu one dish at a time, from the safest to the boldest, then teaching you how to build a balanced meal.

In Book One you learned the *why*: that money quietly loses value, that compounding rewards the patient, that risk and reward are joined at the hip. You ended with a glimpse of the menu. This book is the full tour — and, just as importantly, the recipe for combining the items into a sensible whole.

We'll move deliberately from the **safe end** of the menu (cash and bonds) to the **growth end** (stocks, funds, property and gold), explaining each in plain language: what it actually is, how it makes you money, what can go wrong, and who it suits. Then, in Part IV, we'll assemble them — because the secret isn't picking the “best” investment; it's *mixing* them well.

How each chapter is built

Every chapter opens with **what you'll learn**, unfolds in short numbered **sub-chapters** (1.1, 1.2 ...), and closes with **Key Takeaways** and a quick **Self-Check**. Watch for **In Plain Terms** explainers, **Did You Know?** facts and **Watch Out** warnings. Nothing here needs maths beyond a calculator, and every term is explained the first time it appears.

There is no single “best” investment — only the right mix for your goals, your timeline, and how well you sleep at night.

Read in order: the menu makes most sense from safe to bold, and Part IV depends on the chapters before it. If a particular asset already interests you, skim to its chapter — but do come back for Part IV, where the real wisdom lives.



Let's begin with the one skill that makes every other chapter easier: how to judge any investment.

I

PART ONE

The Ground Rules

Before we tour the menu, you need one portable skill: how to size up any investment with the same four questions. Learn it once, and every option in this book — and every one you meet for the rest of your life — becomes easy to judge.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS | RISK & RETURN | LIQUIDITY | INCOME VS GROWTH

CHAPTER ONE

How to Judge Any Investment

Whether someone offers you a bond, a fund, a flat, a gold coin or a tip from a friend, the same four questions cut straight to the truth. Master them and you'll never again feel lost when money is on the table.

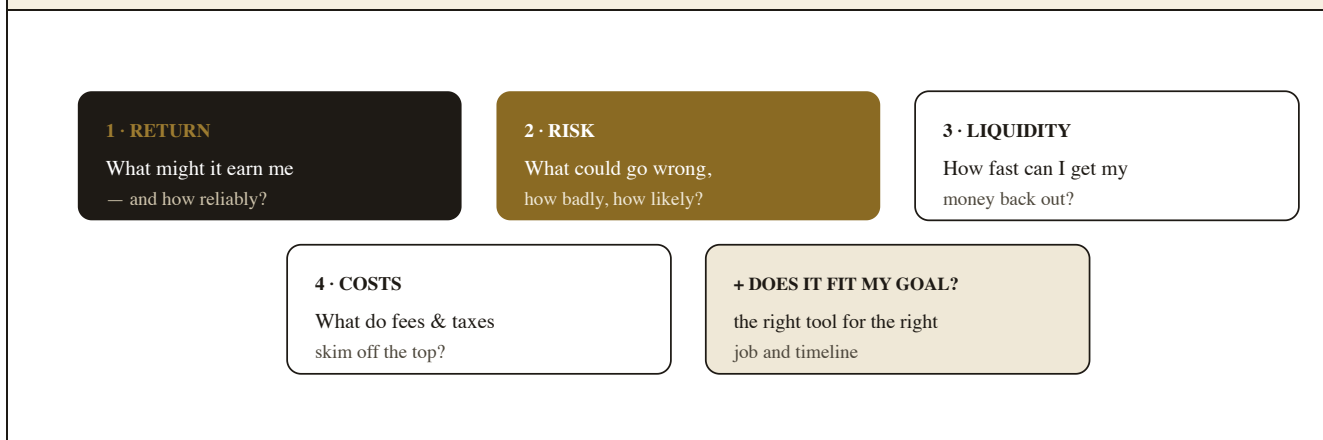
IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- The four questions that judge any investment.
 - Why risk and return can never be separated.
 - What “liquidity” means and why it matters more than beginners think.
 - How fees and taxes quietly devour returns.
-

Every investment, however it's dressed up, can be understood through a handful of plain questions. You don't need jargon or a finance degree — you need a checklist. This chapter is that checklist, and you'll use it in every chapter that follows.

1.1 The Four Questions

Hold any investment up to the light and ask four things:

FIGURE 1.1 · THE FOUR QUESTIONS FOR ANY INVESTMENT

One checklist for everything. *Return, risk, liquidity, costs — plus the overarching test, “does it fit my goal and timeline?” Run any opportunity through these and the fog clears. If someone can’t (or won’t) answer all four, that itself is your answer.*

1.2 Risk and Return Are Joined at the Hip

Book One’s iron law bears repeating because it governs this entire book: **higher potential return always comes with higher risk.** They are two ends of the same stick; you cannot pick one up without the other. This single truth lets you instantly judge any pitch. A savings account offers low return *and* low risk — consistent. A claim of high return with “no risk” is internally contradictory — it cannot exist, so it’s either a misunderstanding or a fraud. When you tour the menu, you’ll see every option sitting honestly somewhere on this trade-off; nothing escapes it.

1.3 Liquidity — Can You Get Your Money Out?

Liquidity is how quickly and cheaply you can turn an investment back into spendable cash. Money in a savings account is highly liquid — withdraw it today. A publicly traded fund is liquid — sell in seconds during market hours. A flat or a piece of land is *illiquid* — selling can take months and cost a chunk in fees. Liquidity matters more than beginners expect, because life springs surprises: if your money is locked in something you can’t sell, you may be forced to borrow at high interest or sell at a terrible price exactly when you need cash. As a rule, the money you might need soon belongs in liquid places; only money you can leave alone for years should go into illiquid ones.

1.4 Costs — the Silent Return-Killers

Two quiet forces skim your returns whether the investment rises or falls: **fees** and **taxes**. A fee that sounds trivial — say 2% a year — is anything but, because it's charged *every year on your whole pot* and it steals from compounding (Book One, Chapter 8). Over decades, a 2% annual fee can quietly consume a third or more of your final wealth compared with a near-free alternative earning the same return. Taxes bite too, often more gently if you hold investments for the long term. You can't control the market, but you *can* control your costs — which makes minimising them the easiest, most reliable “extra return” available to anyone.

In Plain Terms · why a 2% fee is a big deal

Imagine two identical funds, both growing the market's ~7% a year, one charging 0.2% and the other 2%. The cheap one nets ~6.8%; the dear one ~5%. On a sum left for 30 years, that 1.8% yearly gap compounds into a startling difference — often the cheaper fund ends with *far* more, for the exact same investments. The fee isn't a small annual nibble; it's a compounding leak. Always ask: “what does this cost me *every year*?”

WATCH OUT

The questions nobody volunteers

Salespeople love to talk about Question 1 (return) and stay quiet on the rest. The most important information is usually in the questions they *don't* raise: the real risks, how hard it is to get your money out, and the full stack of fees. When an opportunity dazzles you with returns but goes vague on risk, liquidity or costs, slow down — the silence is the signal.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Judge any investment by four questions:** return, risk, liquidity, costs — plus “does it fit my goal?”
2. **Risk and return are inseparable;** “high return, no risk” cannot exist.
3. **Liquidity** is how fast you can get cash back — keep soon-needed money in liquid places.
4. **Fees and taxes compound against you;** minimising costs is the easiest reliable gain.

SELF-CHECK

1. List the four questions you'd ask of any investment.
2. Why is “a safe investment paying 15% guaranteed” a contradiction?
3. Give one liquid and one illiquid investment, and say why liquidity matters.
4. Why can a “small” 2% annual fee cost you a large share of your wealth?

FRONT MATTER

Reader Paths — How to Read This Book by Goal

Fourteen chapters across five parts, plus deep dives on bonds, alternatives and the indexing case. Most readers will benefit from reading in order; here's how to skip ahead if you have a specific goal.

• Path 1 — Building your first portfolio

Read everything in order. The structure (foundations → asset classes → diversification → start) is designed for the first-time investor. About **3 hours** of focused reading.

• Path 2 — I want to know one asset class

Skip directly to the relevant chapter: **Ch 3** (Cash), **Ch 4 + Ch 12** (Bonds — basic + advanced), **Ch 5** (Stocks), **Ch 6** (Funds), **Ch 7** (Property), **Ch 8 + Ch 13** (Alternatives — basic + advanced).

• Path 3 — Already investing, want depth

Skip the basics, jump to **Part V (Ch 12-14)**: bonds in depth (duration, convexity, credit spreads), alternative assets (REITs, commodities, hedge funds, PE), and the empirical case for indexing. About **45 minutes**.

- **Path 4 — Index-only investor**

You're convinced indexing is the right approach and want only the necessary context. Read **Ch 6 (Funds — the Beginner's Best Friend)** and **Ch 14 (The Empirical Case for Indexing)**. Add **Ch 10 (Diversification & Asset Allocation)** for the allocation framework. Total: 30 minutes.

- **Path 5 — The contrarian / active investor**

You're not convinced indexing is right and want to understand the alternatives. Read **Ch 1 (How to Judge Any Investment)**, **Ch 13 (Alternatives in depth)**, and then read **Ch 14** carefully to ensure you understand what you're choosing against.

If you take only one chapter

Read **Chapter 14 — The Empirical Case for Indexing**. The SPIVA data and the fee-drag math together represent the single most evidence-backed recommendation in personal finance. Even if you choose differently, understanding why most professionals lose to indices is essential context.

CHAPTER TWO

The Two Ways to Make Money

Every investment pays you in one of two ways — or both. It either hands you a regular income, or it grows in value so you can sell for more later. Knowing which is which tells you what an investment is really for.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- The two fundamental ways an investment rewards you.
- What “income” investments look like — interest, dividends, rent.
- What “growth” means, and why it can be more powerful (and bumpier).
- Why “total return” is the only honest scoreboard.

As you tour the menu, you'll notice each option leans toward one of two reward styles. Spotting this instantly tells you whether an investment is meant to *pay* you along the way, to *grow* for the future, or both — and which suits your goal.

2.1 Income — Getting Paid Along the Way

Income is cash an investment pays you regularly, just for holding it. It comes in three familiar forms: **interest** from cash and bonds (the fee a borrower pays you for lending), **dividends** from shares (a slice of a company's profits paid to owners), and **rent** from property (what a tenant pays to use it). Income investments are prized when you want a steady, predictable stream — for example, to live on in retirement — and they tend to be a bit calmer than pure growth. The trade-off is that high, steady income usually comes with lower growth.

2.2 Growth — Getting Worth More Over Time

Growth (or “capital appreciation”) is when the investment itself becomes more valuable, so the gain is locked in only when you sell for more than you paid. A share whose business expands, a property in a rising area, a fund that climbs over the years — these reward you through growth. Growth can be more powerful than income over long stretches, because it compounds (Book One, Chapter 8) and you aren't taxed on a gain until you sell. The catch is that growth is *bumpier*: values rise and fall along the way, and the reward is never guaranteed.

2.3 Total Return — the Only Honest Scoreboard

Here's a mistake that fools beginners constantly: judging an investment by only one of its two rewards. A share might pay a small dividend (income) *and* rise in price (growth); a high-rent property might barely appreciate. To compare fairly, add both together into **total return** — income *plus* growth — over the period you held it.

$$\text{Total return \%} = [(\text{income} + \text{price change}) \div \text{starting price}] \times 100$$

Say you buy a share for **\$100**, collect **\$3** in dividends over the year, and it ends at **\$108**:

WORKED CALCULATION · TOTAL RETURN

Income (dividend) = \$3

Growth (price change) = 108 – 100 = \$8

Total return = (3 + 8) ÷ 100 × 100 = **11%**

*Judging by the +8% price rise alone understates it; by the 3% dividend alone, badly so. Only the combined **11%** is the honest scoreboard. (A “growth” stock might be 0% income + 11% price; an “income” stock 6% + 5% — same total, different shape.)*

FIGURE 2.1 · TOTAL RETURN = INCOME + GROWTH

A share bought for \$1,000, held one year:

INCOME: \$30 dividend
GROWTH: price rose to \$1,080 → +\$80

Judge by the

TOTAL RETURN = \$110 on \$1,000 = 11 %

sum, not one part: • A high dividend with a falling price can still be a loss. • A zero-dividend share that doubles is a wonderful result.

Add the two rewards together. *Total return captures everything an investment did for you. Beware the trap of chasing a fat dividend or rent “yield” while ignoring that the underlying value is sinking — the income can be a consolation prize on a losing bet. And remember from Chapter 1: subtract fees and taxes to get your real, in-pocket return.*

DID YOU KNOW?

Reinvested income is a quiet powerhouse

Over very long periods, a surprising share of the stock market's total return has come not from prices rising, but from *dividends being reinvested* — using each payout to buy more shares, which then pay their own dividends, and so on. It's compounding (Book One, Chapter 8) hiding inside the “income” bucket. The lesson for a growing portfolio: unless you need the cash to live on, reinvesting income rather than spending it can dramatically boost long-run results.

WATCH OUT

A high “yield” is not free money

Beginners are easily lured by an investment advertising a very high income “yield.” But an unusually high yield is often a warning, not a gift: it can mean the market expects the underlying value (or the income itself) to fall. As always, judge by *total return* and by the four questions of Chapter 1 — never by the headline payout alone. If a yield looks too good, ask *why* it's so high.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Investments pay two ways:** income (interest, dividends, rent) and growth (rising value).
2. **Income is steadier;** growth can be more powerful but bumpier and only realised on sale.
3. **Total return = income + growth** — the only fair way to compare, after fees and taxes.
4. **A very high yield is often a warning,** not a windfall.

SELF-CHECK

1. Name the three forms of investment income.
2. How does “growth” differ from “income,” and when is each more useful?
3. A fund pays \$40 income and rises \$60 on a \$2,000 holding in a year. What's the total return %?
4. Why can a very high advertised yield be a red flag?

II

PART TWO

The Safe End

We begin the tour where risk is lowest: cash and bonds. These won't make you rich, but they keep you safe, pay you to wait, and steady the bumpier investments to come. Every sensible portfolio holds some of them.

CASH & DEPOSITS | BONDS | INTEREST | SAFETY FIRST

CHAPTER THREE

Cash & Cash-Like Savings

Cash feels too basic to be an “investment,” but it has a vital job: safety and instant access. The skill is knowing exactly what cash is for — and refusing to leave your long-term money there, where inflation slowly eats it.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- The main cash and cash-like options, from instant-access to fixed-term.
 - The trade-off between getting a slightly higher rate and locking your money up.
 - What cash is genuinely good for — and what it is not.
-

Run cash through the four questions (Chapter 1) and the picture is clear: low return, very low risk, high liquidity, low cost. That profile makes cash perfect for some jobs and quietly disastrous for others. Let's see which is which.

3.1 Savings Accounts & Money-Market Funds

The most familiar home for cash is a **savings account** at a bank: instantly accessible, very safe (in many countries deposits are government-insured up to a limit), and paying a modest rate of interest. A close cousin is the **money-market fund** — a low-risk fund that holds very short-term, high-quality debt and aims to keep your money stable while paying a little interest. Both prize *safety and access* over return. They are where your emergency fund and any money you'll need within months should live.

3.2 Term Deposits — Locking Up for a Little More

If you can promise not to touch the money for a set period, a bank will usually pay you a slightly higher, fixed rate through a **term deposit** — known as a *certificate of deposit (CD)* in some countries and a *fixed deposit (FD)* in others. You commit your cash for, say, six months or three years; in return you get a guaranteed rate and your money back at the end. The trade-off is **liquidity**: withdraw early and you typically forfeit some interest or pay a penalty. Term deposits suit money you've earmarked for a known future date.

FIGURE 3.1 · THE CASH LADDER — ACCESS VS. RATE



As you give up access (left → right), the rate rises a little. None of them is meant to beat inflation over the long run.

A small ladder of safety. *Moving right, you trade some access for a slightly better rate — but all three live at the safe, low-return end. Cash earns its keep through certainty and liquidity, never through growth.*

3.3 What Cash Is For — and What It Isn't

Cash is *essential*, for three clear jobs: your **emergency fund** (Book One, Chapter 5), money you'll **need within a couple of years** (a deposit, a wedding, fees), and a small reserve of “dry powder” to stay calm and opportunistic. For these, cash's stability is exactly right.

What cash is *not* for is your **long-term wealth**. As Book One showed, money parked in cash quietly loses purchasing power to inflation year after year. Over a decade or three, that's a large, certain loss. So the rule is simple: keep enough cash for safety and near-term needs, then move the rest up the menu toward investments that can outrun inflation. Cash is the foundation of the house — not the house itself.

WATCH OUT**The comfort trap**

Because cash never visibly “drops,” it feels like the responsible, safe choice — and so many people leave their entire savings in it for decades, out of fear of markets. But that comfort is an illusion: they suffer a slow, guaranteed defeat by inflation that often dwarfs the short-term wobbles they were avoiding. Holding *too much* cash for too long is one of the most common and costly mistakes in personal finance.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Cash = low return, very low risk, high liquidity.** Its value is safety and instant access.
2. **Savings accounts & money-market funds** for instant access; **term deposits (CD/FD)** pay a bit more if you lock up.
3. **Cash is for the emergency fund and near-term needs** — not for long-term wealth.
4. **Too much cash, too long, is a costly mistake** — inflation erodes it with certainty.

SELF-CHECK

1. Run a savings account through the four questions of Chapter 1.
2. What do you give up, and gain, by choosing a term deposit over a savings account?
3. Name the three legitimate jobs cash should do for you.
4. Why is keeping all your long-term money in cash a “comfort trap”?

CHAPTER FOUR

Bonds — Being the Lender

With a bond, you stop being a borrower and become the bank: you lend your money to a government or company, and they pay you interest for the privilege. Bonds are the steady, sensible middle of the menu — safer than stocks, more rewarding than cash.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- What a bond actually is — in plain terms.
- The difference between government and corporate bonds.
- The single most surprising bond fact: prices move opposite to interest rates.
- The three risks even “safe” bonds carry.

Imagine you lend \$10,000 to a friend. He promises: \$500 every year, and your \$10,000 back after five years. Congratulations — you just created a bond. Now imagine the "friend" is a government. That's the bond market.

If a stock means *owning* a piece of a business (Chapter 5), a bond means *lending* to one. That single distinction — owner versus lender — explains everything about how bonds behave, why they're steadier than stocks, and where they belong in your plan.

4.1 What a Bond Is

A **bond** is a loan, sliced into a tradeable certificate. When a government or company needs money, it can borrow from the public by issuing bonds. You hand over a sum (the **principal**, or face value); in return you receive regular interest payments (the **coupon**) for a set number of years, and then your principal

back on a fixed date (the **maturity**). Lend \$1,000 at a 5% coupon for ten years, and you'd collect \$50 a year for ten years, then your \$1,000 back at the end. Predictable and contractual — that's the appeal.

FIGURE 4.1 · ANATOMY OF A BOND



A loan you can hold or trade. Steady coupons along the way, principal returned at maturity. Because the payments are fixed and contractual, bonds are far more predictable than stocks — which is exactly why they steady a portfolio. (Bonds can also be sold before maturity, at a price that moves — see 4.3.)

4.2 Government vs. Corporate Bonds

Who you lend to decides your risk and reward. **Government bonds** from stable countries are considered among the safest investments on earth — a major government rarely fails to repay its own currency — so they pay a relatively low rate. **Corporate bonds** are loans to companies; because a company is more likely to run into trouble than a stable government, they pay a higher rate to compensate you for that extra risk. At the riskier extreme sit “high-yield” (or “junk”) bonds from shakier borrowers, which tempt you with fat coupons precisely because there's a real chance you won't be fully repaid. The pattern is Chapter 1's law again: more reward, more risk.

4.3 The Bond See-Saw

Here is the one bond fact that surprises everyone, and it's worth understanding: **when interest rates in the economy rise, the market price of existing bonds falls — and vice versa.** Why? Imagine you hold a bond paying a 3% coupon. If new bonds start being issued at 5%, no one will buy

yours at full price when they can get 5% elsewhere — so to sell it, you must drop your price until its effective return matches the new 5%. The reverse happens when rates fall: your higher-paying old bond becomes more valuable. You only lock in this price change if you *sell* early; hold to maturity and you still get your principal back. But the see-saw is real, and it's why even “safe” government bonds can lose market value in a year when rates jump.

WORKED CALCULATION · WHY THE PRICE MUST FALL

Your bond pays a fixed **\$30/yr** coupon (3% of \$1,000 face).

Current yield = annual coupon ÷ price.

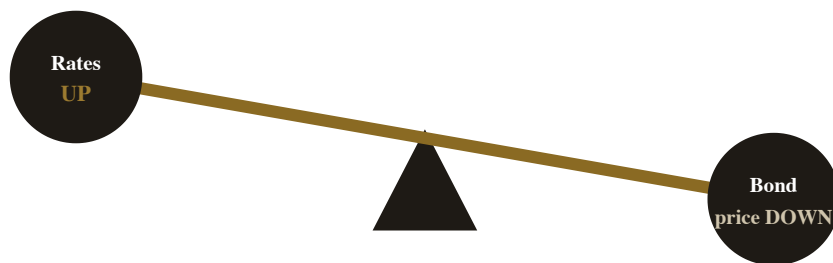
At face value: $30 \div 1,000 = 3.0\%$

But new bonds now pay 5%. To yield 5%, your bond's price must fall to:

price = $30 \div 0.05 = \mathbf{\$600}$

A buyer paying \$600 for a \$30 coupon gets $30 \div 600 = 5\%$ — matching the market. So rates rising 3%→5% knocks your bond's resale price from \$1,000 toward ~\$600. Hold to maturity and you still get \$1,000 back; sell early and you take the loss. That's the see-saw, in numbers.

FIGURE 4.2 · THE BOND SEE-SAW



When one side goes up, the other goes down. Longer-dated bonds swing the most.

Rates up, prices down — always. Existing bonds must compete with newly issued ones. This see-saw is the main reason a “safe” bond fund can post a loss in a year of rising rates — a fact that catches many beginners (and, occasionally, big institutions) by surprise.

4.4 The Three Risks of “Safe” Bonds

Bonds are *safer* than stocks, not *risk-free*. They carry three risks worth naming. **Credit risk** — the borrower may fail to pay (low for stable governments, real for weak companies). **Interest-rate risk** — the see-saw above, which can dent the price if you need to sell early. And **inflation risk** — a fixed 3% coupon is a poor deal if inflation runs at 6%, because your interest doesn't keep up with rising prices. “Safe” always begs the question: *safe against which risk?* Bonds defend well against the wild swings of stocks, but they have their own, quieter vulnerabilities.

In Plain Terms · why hold bonds at all?

If bonds grow less than stocks, why bother? Two reasons. First, **steadiness**: bonds tend to be calmer than stocks and sometimes hold up (or rise) when stocks fall, smoothing your overall ride. Second, **predictable income**: those fixed coupons are valuable when you actually need to spend, as in retirement. Bonds aren't the engine of wealth — stocks are — but they're the suspension that keeps the journey bearable, which is why most balanced portfolios hold some.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A bond is a tradeable loan**: you lend principal, receive coupons (interest), get principal back at maturity.
2. **Government bonds are safest (lower rate); corporate/“junk” bonds pay more for more risk.**
3. **Bond prices move opposite to interest rates** — the see-saw — so even safe bonds can lose value if sold early after rates rise.
4. **Bonds are safer, not safe**: mind credit, interest-rate and inflation risk. They steady a portfolio and provide income.

SELF-CHECK

1. Explain a bond as if to a friend, using the words principal, coupon and maturity.
2. Why does a corporate bond usually pay more than a government bond?
3. Interest rates in the economy rise sharply. What happens to the price of bonds you already own, and why?
4. Name the three risks bonds carry, despite being “safe.”

III

PART THREE

The Growth End

Now the engines of wealth: ownership. Stocks, funds, property and gold won't promise the steady calm of cash and bonds — but over long stretches, this is where money is actually grown. Higher reward, higher risk, exactly as the law promised.

STOCKS | FUNDS & ETFs | PROPERTY | GOLD & ALTERNATIVES

CHAPTER FIVE

Stocks — Owning a Slice

A stock isn't a lottery ticket or a number on a screen — it's a genuine slice of ownership in a real business. Understand that one idea and the stock market stops being a casino and becomes what it really is: a way to own the world's companies.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- What a share really is — ownership, not a bet.
- The two ways a stock pays you (and how that links to Chapter 2).
- Why stocks have grown over the long run.
- The serious risk of betting on single companies.

Three friends each put \$10,000 into "the stock market" in March 2000. Twenty-five years later one has \$180,000. Another has \$40,000. The third has \$2,000. They invested the same amount, on the same day, in the same place. The only difference was which stocks they picked. That's what this chapter is really about.

If bonds are lending (Chapter 4), stocks are *owning*. This is the boldest, most rewarding end of the everyday menu — the part that has built the most wealth over history, and the part most prone to fear, hype and mistakes. Let's see it clearly.

5.1 What a Share Really Is

A company divides its ownership into many equal pieces called **shares** (or stock). Buy one, and you literally own a tiny fraction of that business — its products, brand, profits and future. Own a share of a great company alongside millions of others, and you are, in a small but real and legal way, a part-owner

of it. You are not betting on a price; you are buying a stake in an enterprise. That shift in mindset — from “gambling on a ticker” to “owning a business” — is the difference between an investor and a punter, and it changes every decision you make.

PLATE 5.1 · A STOCK EXCHANGE — THE MARKETPLACE FOR OWNERSHIP



Where ownership is traded. *A stock exchange like this is simply a marketplace where slices of the world's businesses change hands — not a casino, however it's portrayed. When you buy a share, you join the ranks of a company's owners.*

PHOTOGRAPH VIA WIKIMEDIA COMMONS, USED UNDER A FREE LICENCE.

5.2 How a Stock Pays You

Stocks reward you through both channels you met in Chapter 2. **Growth (capital appreciation):** as the business grows more valuable, each share is worth more, so you can one day sell for more than you paid. **Income (dividends):** many established companies pay out a slice of their profits to shareholders as cash, just for holding the share. A young, fast-growing company may pay no dividend (ploughing profits back into growth), while a mature one may pay a generous one. Your *total return* (Chapter 2) is the two combined — and, historically, the bulk of long-run stock wealth has come from growth plus *reinvested* dividends compounding together.



INVESTOR PROFILE

WARREN BUFFETT — B. 1930

Began investing at age 11, took control of a struggling textile mill (Berkshire Hathaway) in 1965, and over the following sixty years compounded its book value at roughly 20% per year — an achievement no other investor has matched over a comparable horizon.

What he believes: buy excellent businesses at fair prices and hold them indefinitely; ignore the daily noise of markets; invest only in what you understand. **What he got right:** the discipline of patience and the recognition that markets are often wrong about specific businesses for years at a time. **What he got wrong:** missed most of the technology revolution until very late (he bought Apple in 2016, at age 86); has openly said his methods don't translate well to the modern hyper-information age for many small investors. He has also been a vocal advocate of just buying an S&P 500 index fund — "the best advice I can give to most investors" — which is the same answer Book 2 Ch 14 reaches from a completely different direction.

5.3 Why Stocks Grow Over the Long Run

Here's the deep reason stocks have rewarded patient owners: a share is a claim on a *productive*, adaptable thing — a business full of people working to earn more, sell more and grow. As economies expand, populations grow and productivity improves, the collective earnings of companies tend to rise over time, and share prices follow. Individual companies fail, but the broad market — the whole basket of them — has trended powerfully upward across every long stretch of history, rewarding those who stayed invested through the storms. Stocks are, in essence, a long-term bet on human enterprise continuing to grow — which, so far, it always has.

FIGURE 5.1 · A SHARE: TWO WAYS TO WIN, ONE WAY TO LOSE

THE REWARDS

↑ Growth — the business grows more valuable
+ Dividends — a slice of profits, paid to you

THE RISK

Unlimited upside, but the value can fall — even to zero if the company fails.
Owners are paid

last if it collapses.

The owner's deal. *As an owner you share fully in the upside — there's no ceiling — but you also bear the risk, with no floor: if the business fails, shareholders are paid last and can lose everything. Unlimited reward, real risk: the bargain at the bold end of the menu.*

FROM HISTORY · THE MODERN BUBBLE

THE DOT-COM BUBBLE — WHEN GROWTH IS MISTAKEN FOR VALUE

2000

By March 2000, the NASDAQ Composite had quintupled in three years. Companies with no revenue, no profit, and sometimes no actual product were valued at billions. The conventional wisdom was that the internet had changed the rules of business; *this time was different*. It always is.

From the March 2000 peak the NASDAQ fell 78%. The S&P 500 fell 49% over the next two-and-a-half years. Many of the most prominent dot-com companies were liquidated; their shareholders received nothing. Even the businesses that *were* ultimately good ones — Amazon, Cisco, Microsoft — saw their stocks fall 80-95% on the way down. Amazon shareholders waited a decade to break even from the 2000 high.

The lesson is not that growth investing doesn't work. The lesson is that *price paid matters even for a great business*. A wonderful company at 100× earnings is often a worse investment than a mediocre company at 10×. The buyer at the top, no matter how right about the business, has paid too much for the growth that follows.

CAUTIONARY TALE — RAJ

Raj had a clear thesis. The company he worked for — a mid-cap pharmaceutical — was about to launch a blockbuster drug. He knew the product, knew the team, was certain the launch would succeed. So in 2018, at age 31, he put his entire \$48,000 in savings into the company's stock and added another \$15,000 of borrowed money.

The launch worked. Revenue grew 40% in two years. The stock went up 60% from his entry. Raj was right about the business.

Then a single ingredient supplier was caught falsifying quality data. The regulator issued a global recall. The company's main drug pipeline was halted pending investigation. The stock fell 78% in three months. The investigation cleared the company nine months later, but by then the damage was done — institutional investors had fled, the stock had been crushed, and Raj had been forced to sell at the bottom to repay his loan. He lost everything plus a debt that took him three years to clear.

What Raj got right: his analysis of the business. **What he got wrong:** the conviction that being right about the business was enough. Even a great company can be hit by something the analyst couldn't see. **The lesson:** never put more than 5-10% of your portfolio in any single stock, no matter how certain you are. The 5-10% rule isn't there for the times you're wrong — it's there for the times you're right and unlucky.

5.4 The Danger of Single Stocks

Here is the crucial warning. While *stocks as a group* have grown reliably over the long run, *any single company* can stumble, stagnate or collapse entirely — and plenty of famous, “can’t-fail” names have gone to zero, taking their shareholders’ money with them. Putting a large share of your savings into one or two companies is not investing; it’s concentrated betting. The fix is the most important idea in the next chapter and in Part IV: instead of trying to pick the one winner, you can own a *whole basket* of companies at once through a fund — capturing the market’s long-run growth without betting your future on any single business.

DID YOU KNOW?

Most of the market's gains come from a few big winners

Studies of long-run stock returns find something startling: a small minority of companies generate the lion’s share of the entire market’s wealth, while a large fraction of individual stocks underperform or even lose money over their lifetimes. This is precisely why trying to hand-pick winners is so hard — and why owning the *whole basket* (a fund) is so powerful: you’re guaranteed to hold those few big winners, instead of risking that you miss them.

WATCH OUT

A stock is a business, not a ticker

The most damaging beginner habit is buying a stock because it’s “going up” or because of a tip, with no idea what the company does or whether it earns money. That’s gambling. Whenever you consider an individual stock, remember you’re buying part of a real business, and run it through the four questions (Chapter 1). And never put money you can’t afford to lose into a single company — that’s what funds are for.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A share is real part-ownership of a business** — not a bet on a number.
2. **Stocks pay through growth + dividends**; total return combines both.
3. **The broad market has grown over the long run** because it's a claim on growing human enterprise.
4. **Single stocks can go to zero** — own a diversified basket (a fund) rather than betting on one.

SELF-CHECK

1. What do you actually own when you buy a share?
2. Name the two ways a stock can reward you.
3. Why has the broad stock market tended to rise over long periods?
4. Why is putting most of your savings in one company dangerous, and what's the fix?

CHAPTER SIX

Funds — the Beginner's Best Friend

You don't have to pick winning companies one by one — and you probably shouldn't try. A single fund lets you own a slice of hundreds of businesses at once, cheaply and automatically. For most people, this is the single most useful investment ever invented.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- What a fund is, and how pooling gives instant diversification.
 - The difference between “active” funds and low-cost “index” funds.
 - What an ETF is, versus a traditional mutual fund.
 - Why low fees matter more than almost anything else.
-

Chapter 5 ended with a problem — single stocks are risky — and this chapter is the elegant solution. The fund is how an ordinary person captures the long-run growth of the whole market without gambling on any one company, without expert knowledge, and without much effort.

6.1 What a Fund Is

A **fund** pools money from many investors and uses it to buy a large basket of investments — dozens or hundreds of stocks, or bonds, or both. When you put money in, you own a proportional slice of the entire basket. With one purchase and a modest sum, you instantly own a piece of hundreds of companies — the diversification (Book One) that would be impossible to build yourself. If one company in the basket fails, it barely dents your holding, because it's one of hundreds. This is why a broad fund is the standard first step for a beginner.

FIGURE 6.1 · ONE PURCHASE, HUNDREDS OF COMPANIES

Diversification in a single click — the failure of any one company can't sink you.

Pooling = instant diversification. *With a small sum you own a sliver of hundreds of companies — impossible to assemble yourself. This is the fund's quiet genius, and why it's the most common, sensible first investment in the world.*

6.2 Active vs. Index Funds

Funds come in two philosophies. An **active fund** pays a professional manager to try to *beat* the market by cleverly picking stocks — and charges a higher fee for the effort. An **index fund** doesn't try to beat the market; it simply buys the *whole* market (or a defined slice of it) and matches its return, at a tiny cost. This is called *passive* investing. The surprise that decades of evidence keep confirming: after fees, the *majority* of active managers fail to beat a simple low-cost index fund over the long run. The cheap, “unambitious” index fund quietly outperforms most of the experts — which is wonderful news for beginners, because it means the best choice is also the simplest and cheapest.

6.3 ETFs vs. Mutual Funds

You'll meet two formats for funds, and the difference is mostly mechanical. A traditional **mutual fund** is bought and sold once a day at a price set after the market closes, usually directly from the fund company. An **ETF** (exchange-traded fund) is a fund that trades on the stock exchange like a share, so you can buy or sell it any time the market is open, often at a very low cost. Both can be index funds; both give you the same diversification. For most long-term investors the choice between them is minor — what matters far more is that the fund is **broad and low-cost**.

AUTHOR'S NOTE · THE ACTIVE-FUND INDUSTRY

Be careful with what comes next, because the modern financial industry will not let you hear this clearly. The bulk of active mutual funds — the ones with the glossy brochures, the historical-returns hindsight charts, the relationship managers calling you — exist to extract a fee, not to beat the market. The empirical record is overwhelming: 80-90% of active funds underperform their benchmark over 10+ years, persistence in the winners is essentially zero, and fee compounding alone explains most of the gap. The industry knows this. Vanguard's founder Jack Bogle spent fifty years saying so, and the data has only gotten more damning since. *Anyone selling you active management as superior is either ill-informed or hopes you are.* Listen for the difference.

6.4 Why Fees Matter So Much

We met this in Chapter 1, and it's worth hammering because it's the one lever you fully control. A fund's annual fee (its “expense ratio”) is charged every year on your whole balance, and it compounds against you. Index funds often charge a tiny fraction of a percent; many active funds charge ten times more. Over an investing lifetime, that gap can quietly transfer a large share of your potential wealth from you to the fund company — for no extra return. When choosing a fund, the most reliable predictor of good long-term results isn't the manager's brilliance or last year's chart; it's the *lowest fee*.

This sounds abstract until you run the numbers. Compare two funds, both earning 8% a year before fees, on a \$10,000 investment over 30 years — one charging a 0.1% index fee, the other a 1.0% active fee (so they net 7.9% vs. 7.0%):

WORKED CALCULATION · WHAT A 1% FEE REALLY COSTS

Low-fee (nets 7.9%): $10,000 \times (1.079)^{30} = \mathbf{\$97,900}$

High-fee (nets 7.0%): $10,000 \times (1.070)^{30} = \mathbf{\$76,100}$

Difference = $97,900 - 76,100 = \mathbf{\$21,800}$

A fee gap of less than 1% a year quietly ate ~22% of the final pot — about \$21,800 on a \$10,000 start — and handed it to the fund company, for

no extra return. The fee compounds against you exactly as your money compounds for you. This is why “lowest fee” is the single most reliable fund-picking rule.

In Plain Terms · the beginner's default

If all of this feels like a lot, here is the distilled answer that suits most people: a single **broad, low-cost index fund** — one that holds a wide swathe of the market — bought regularly and held for the long term. It gives you instant diversification, captures the market's long-run growth, costs almost nothing, and requires no stock-picking skill. It is boring, and it quietly beats most of the clever alternatives. We'll build on exactly this in Part IV.

WATCH OUT

Don't chase last year's “top” fund

Apps love to show you whichever fund “returned 40% last year” at the top of a glowing list. But last year's star is very often next year's laggard — performance chases its own tail, and the high fees of flashy active funds drag on returns. The regulator-mandated warning is true: *past performance does not predict future results*. A cheap, broad index fund held for decades beats hopping between yesterday's winners.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A fund pools money** to give you a diversified basket of hundreds of investments in one purchase.
2. **Index (passive) funds match the market cheaply** and beat most active funds over the long run.
3. **ETFs trade like shares; mutual funds price once daily** — both work; broad & low-cost is what matters.
4. **Low fees are the most reliable edge** you control; for most people a broad, low-cost index fund is the ideal default.

SELF-CHECK

1. How does a fund solve the “single stock is risky” problem from Chapter 5?
2. What's the difference between an active fund and an index fund — and which usually wins, net of fees?
3. In one line, how does an ETF differ from a traditional mutual fund?
4. Why is the fund's fee such a powerful predictor of your long-run result?

CHAPTER SEVEN

Property & Real Estate

Bricks and land have built more everyday fortunes than almost anything — and trapped plenty of people too. Property is powerful precisely because of borrowing, and dangerous for exactly the same reason. Here's the honest picture.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- The difference between your home and an investment property.
- The four ways property can pay you — and the role of borrowing.
- How to own property without becoming a landlord (REITs).
- The real catches: it's illiquid, it's not passive, and leverage cuts both ways.

Property feels different from stocks and funds — it's solid, visible, something you can stand inside. That tangibility makes it emotionally appealing, which is all the more reason to judge it coolly with the four questions (Chapter 1), because its quirks — especially borrowing and illiquidity — trip up many beginners.

7.1 Your Home vs. an Investment Property

First, a distinction people blur. The **home you live in** is partly an investment and partly a lifestyle choice and a forced savings plan — but it doesn't pay you rent, and you can't easily sell a bedroom when you need cash. It's valuable, but it's not a pure money-making asset. An **investment property** — one you rent out — is the true investment: it's meant to generate income and growth. Both can be worthwhile; just don't kid yourself that a large, expensive home you live in is the same thing as an income-producing investment.

PLATE 7.1 · RESIDENTIAL PROPERTY — SOLID, VISIBLE, AND OFTEN BOUGHT WITH BORROWED MONEY



Bricks, mortar & mortgages. *Property is tangible and emotionally appealing — which is all the more reason to judge it coolly: for its four returns, its illiquidity, and the double-edged borrowing behind it.*

PHOTOGRAPH VIA WIKIMEDIA COMMONS, USED UNDER A FREE LICENCE.

7.2 The Four Returns — and the Power of Borrowing

A rental property can pay you in up to four ways at once, which is what makes it so potent: **rent** (income), **appreciation** (the property rising in value), **loan paydown** (your tenant's rent gradually pays off your mortgage, building your equity), and often **tax advantages** (which vary by country). The amplifier behind all of this is **leverage** — borrowing. Property is the one asset ordinary people routinely buy mostly with borrowed money: put down a fraction, control the whole thing. If the property rises, you gain on the *full* value while having invested only your deposit — magnifying your return. But read the next idea carefully, because that same lever runs in reverse.

FIGURE 7.1 · PROPERTY — FOUR RETURNS, ONE DOUBLE-EDGED LEVER

All four, amplified by LEVERAGE (borrowing) ...

... which magnifies gains AND losses. A price fall can wipe out a leveraged buyer.

Four engines, one risky amplifier. *Rent, appreciation, tenant-funded loan paydown and tax breaks can compound together — which is property's superpower. But all of it is magnified by borrowing, and magnification works in both directions.*

7.3 REITs — Property Without the Hassle

If you like the idea of property income but not tenants, repairs and giant mortgages, there's an elegant alternative: a **REIT** (Real Estate Investment Trust). A REIT is a company that owns large, income-producing real estate — offices, malls, warehouses, apartments — and trades on the stock exchange like a share. Buy a REIT and you own a slice of a big professionally-managed property portfolio for a small sum, collect your share of the rental income (REITs typically pay out most of it), and can sell any time the market is open. It's the diversification-and-liquidity logic of funds (Chapter 6), applied to real estate — often the most practical way for a beginner to add property to a portfolio.

7.4 The Catches

Direct property carries three honest drawbacks the glossy stories omit. It's **illiquid** — selling can take months and cost a hefty slice in fees, so your money is locked up. It's **not truly passive** — “passive income” from rentals still means tenants, repairs, vacancies and paperwork; it's a part-time business, not a hands-off fund. And **leverage cuts both ways** — the borrowing that magnifies your gains will just as ruthlessly magnify your losses, and a big enough price fall can leave you owing more than the

property is worth. Property can be a genuinely excellent investment; just go in with eyes open to these realities, and never buy property you couldn't hold through a downturn.

WATCH OUT

“Property only ever goes up” is a dangerous myth

In some places and eras, a near-religious belief takes hold that house prices can only rise. History has repeatedly, painfully proved otherwise — property markets *can* fall, and falls are especially brutal for leveraged buyers. Treat any “can't lose” asset, property included, with extra suspicion. The four questions (Chapter 1) apply to a flat just as much as to a fund — including the unglamorous ones about liquidity and what could go wrong.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Your home is a lifestyle asset; a rental is the true investment property.**
2. **Property can pay four ways** (rent, appreciation, loan paydown, tax) — amplified by borrowing.
3. **Leverage magnifies gains *and* losses;** a price fall can wipe out a leveraged buyer.
4. **REITs** give property exposure with diversification and liquidity; direct property is illiquid and not truly passive.

SELF-CHECK

1. Why is the home you live in not the same as an investment property?
2. List the four ways a rental property can pay you.
3. How does leverage magnify both gains and losses?
4. What is a REIT, and what two property drawbacks does it solve?

CHAPTER EIGHT

Gold & Alternatives

Beyond the core menu sit the “alternatives” — gold, commodities, collectibles, crypto. Some have a real, modest role as diversifiers; others are pure speculation dressed as investing. The skill is telling them apart and keeping them in their place: spice, never the meal.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- Why gold is held — and its one big limitation.
- What commodities and collectibles offer (and their traps).
- An honest, brief take on cryptocurrency.
- The golden rule for all alternatives.

Everything so far — cash, bonds, stocks, funds, property — forms the core of a sensible portfolio. The alternatives in this chapter are the seasoning: a small amount can add something useful, but make them the main dish and you'll usually regret it. Let's keep them honest.

8.1 Gold — the Ancient Hedge

Humans have trusted **gold** as money and a store of value for thousands of years. Its appeal as an investment is mainly as a **hedge**: gold often holds or gains value when currencies wobble, inflation spikes, or markets panic — moments when it can rise while stocks fall, cushioning a portfolio. You can hold it physically, or more practically through gold-backed funds that trade like shares. But gold has one big limitation: it produces *nothing*. A share represents a business that earns; a bond pays interest; a property collects rent. Gold just sits there, its price set purely by what the next person will pay. That's why it's a *diversifier* — a small slice to steady the ride — and not a foundation for building wealth.

8.2 Commodities & Collectibles

Other tangibles get marketed as investments: **commodities** (oil, metals, agricultural goods) and **collectibles** (art, wine, watches, rare cards). Like gold, none of them produces income — your only hope of profit is selling to someone for more later. Commodity prices are notoriously volatile and driven by forces (weather, geopolitics) almost no individual can predict. Collectibles can occasionally soar, but they're illiquid, costly to buy and store, easy to fake, and depend entirely on fashion. For the overwhelming majority of investors, these belong in the “interesting hobby” category, not the serious-portfolio one. Enjoy the art on your wall; don't bet your retirement on it.

8.3 Cryptocurrency — an Honest, Brief Word

Cryptocurrency (such as Bitcoin) is digital money built on a clever technology that lets value move online without a bank in the middle. The underlying idea is genuinely innovative, and some believe certain cryptocurrencies may become a lasting store of value. But for a beginner, three sober truths matter. It is **extremely volatile** — prices can halve, or double, in weeks. It produces **no income** — like gold, its price is purely what the next buyer will pay. And it is a magnet for **hype, scams and manipulation**, with countless tokens having gone to zero. If you choose to hold any, treat it as the *highest-risk, smallest* slice of your portfolio — money you could genuinely afford to lose entirely — never your foundation, and never money you'll need.

FIGURE 8.1 · CORE VS. SPICE

Keep alternatives in proportion. *The income-producing core (businesses, loans, property) is what reliably builds wealth over time. Non-producing alternatives can diversify or hedge in small doses — but the bigger the “spice” slice grows, the more you’ve drifted from investing toward speculating.*

8.4 The Golden Rule for Alternatives

Here is the rule that keeps you safe across this entire chapter: **alternatives are spice, not the meal.** A small allocation to gold can genuinely steady a portfolio; a tiny, can-afford-to-lose dabble in something speculative is a personal choice. But the moment alternatives become a large part of your wealth — the moment the hope of a quick, dramatic gain pulls you away from the boring, income-producing core — you’ve stopped investing and started gambling. Build your house on the core; let the alternatives be, at most, a thin decorative layer on top.

DID YOU KNOW?

An asset that earns nothing relies entirely on the “next buyer”

There’s a useful test for any asset: *if you could never sell it, would it still pay you anything?* A business pays profits, a bond pays interest, a rental pays rent — so they have value even without a buyer waiting. Gold, collectibles and most crypto pay nothing — their entire value depends on someone else paying more later. That’s not necessarily bad, but it’s a fundamentally different (and more fragile) kind of value, and it’s why these belong in the “spice” category.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Gold is a hedge** that can rise when markets wobble — but it produces no income.
2. **Commodities & collectibles** are volatile, income-less, and mostly a hobby, not a core holding.
3. **Crypto:** innovative but extremely volatile, income-less and scam-prone — at most a tiny, losable slice.
4. **Alternatives are spice, not the meal** — build wealth on the income-producing core.

SELF-CHECK

1. Why is gold considered a hedge, and what is its big limitation?
2. Apply the “would it pay you if you could never sell it?” test to a business, a bond, and gold.
3. State three sober truths about cryptocurrency for a beginner.
4. What is the golden rule for all alternatives?

IV

PART FOUR

Putting It Together

You've toured the whole menu. Now the real skill: combining the options into a balanced plan, matching it to your goals, and actually starting. This is where knowledge becomes a portfolio you can hold for life.

DIVERSIFICATION & ALLOCATION

GOALS & STEADY INVESTING

HOW TO START

CHAPTER NINE

Diversification & Asset Allocation

The secret isn't finding the one best investment — it's mixing several so that no single one can sink you, in proportions that fit your life. Get this mix right and the individual choices matter far less than you'd think.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- Why diversification is the closest thing to a free lunch.
- What “asset allocation” is, and why it matters more than stock-picking.
- How the right mix shifts with your age and goals.
- How rebalancing quietly makes you buy low and sell high.

Having met cash, bonds, stocks, funds, property and gold, the question becomes: how much of each? That decision — your *asset allocation* — turns out to be the most important one you'll make, more important than which particular stock or fund you choose.

9.1 Don't Put All Your Eggs in One Basket

You met diversification in Book One; here it earns its central role. The idea is ancient and simple: spread your money across *different* investments so the failure of any one can't ruin you. Its power is mathematical, not just folksy — by combining things that don't all move together (when stocks fall, bonds or gold may hold steady), you can reduce your overall risk *without* giving up much expected return. That's why it's called the only “free lunch” in finance. The key word is *different*: ten companies in one industry, or three funds that all hold the same giant stocks, isn't real diversification. Spread across asset types, industries, and ideally countries.

9.2 Asset Allocation — the Dial That Matters Most

Asset allocation is simply how you divide your money among the big asset types — chiefly stocks (growth, risky), bonds (steadier), and cash (safe). Decades of research point to a striking conclusion: this broad mix explains the great majority of how your portfolio behaves over time — far more than which specific stocks or funds you pick. In other words, deciding “70% stocks, 30% bonds” matters more than agonising over *which* stocks. This is liberating: you don't need to be a brilliant stock-picker, you need a sensible allocation and the discipline to stick with it.

PRIYA — THE ALLOCATION QUESTION

Priya has \$40,000 in her portfolio. Currently it sits 100% in two equity mutual funds her financial advisor recommended three years ago. She knows she should diversify; she doesn't quite know *how*. She is 35, with a four-year-old daughter. Retirement is 20-25 years away. Her daughter's college is 14 years away. Her husband has a stable government job with a pension.

The "right" answer for Priya is not one allocation but several. Her retirement money (15-year-plus horizon) can be heavily equity. Her daughter's education money (14-year horizon) can be mostly equity but should taper down by year 10. The emergency reserve (immediate horizon) should be in cash. *One person can have three allocations.* That is the framework of Chapter 10 of Book 1, applied to Priya. She finishes this book with three pots, not one, and a much clearer sense of how each is doing its job.

9.3 The Mix Shifts With Your Life

How much risk (stocks) versus safety (bonds and cash) should you hold? It depends mostly on your **time horizon** (Book One, Chapter 9): the longer until you need the money, the more stocks you can hold, because you have years to ride out crashes and let growth compound. As your goal approaches, you shift toward safety so a bad year can't derail you.

FIGURE 9.1 · A SIMPLE ALLOCATION BY LIFE STAGE**YOUNG · long horizon**

~85% stocks

safe

MID-LIFE

~60% stocks

~40% bonds/cash

NEAR / IN RETIREMENT

~30%

~70% bonds/cash

■ Stocks (growth)

■ Bonds & cash (stability)

A rough guide, not a rule. A common shorthand: keep roughly “100 minus your age” percent in stocks, and adjust to taste.

One dial, set to your life. *More stocks when young and patient; more bonds and cash as the money is needed sooner. The exact numbers matter less than the principle. Set the dial to a level that lets you sleep and stay invested through a crash — the best allocation is the one you'll actually keep.*

9.4 Rebalancing — Buying Low on Autopilot

Over time, your mix drifts. A great year for stocks might push your “70% stocks” up to 80%, quietly making your portfolio riskier than you intended. **Rebalancing** means periodically — say once a year — selling a little of whatever has grown too big and topping up whatever has shrunk, to return to your target mix. It feels backwards (you're trimming your winners), but it mechanically forces you to *sell high and buy low*, and it keeps your risk from silently creeping up. Once or twice a year is plenty; more tinkering usually hurts. It's a small, unemotional habit that does a surprising amount of good.

WATCH OUT

Set the dial for your worst self, not your bravest

Everyone is a daring, high-stocks investor in a rising market. Your *true* risk tolerance is revealed only when your portfolio drops 30% and your stomach lurches. A “perfect” aggressive allocation you panic out of at the bottom is far worse than a “good enough” moderate one you calmly hold. Choose a mix you could live with through a brutal year — because there will be brutal years, and holding through them is where the returns are won.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Diversification** across *different* assets cuts risk without sacrificing much return — the only free lunch.
2. **Asset allocation** (your stock/bond/cash mix) drives most of your results — more than stock-picking.
3. **Hold more stocks when young**, more bonds/cash as the goal nears; “100 minus age” is a rough guide.
4. **Rebalance once or twice a year** to sell high and buy low automatically — and pick a mix you can hold through a crash.

SELF-CHECK

1. Why is owning ten companies in the same industry not true diversification?
2. What is asset allocation, and why does it matter more than which stock you pick?
3. Why should a younger person generally hold more stocks?
4. How does rebalancing make you “buy low and sell high”?

CHAPTER TEN

Goal-Based & Steady Investing

Two simple habits turn a good allocation into real results: matching each pot of money to a specific goal, and investing a fixed amount regularly, automatically, no matter what the market is doing. Together they remove guesswork and emotion — the two great destroyers of returns.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- How to match each goal to the right mix and timeline.
- Why investing a steady amount regularly beats trying to time the market.
- How automating it removes emotion from the equation.

Allocation tells you the *mix*; this chapter tells you the *method*. The method is almost embarrassingly simple — and that simplicity is exactly why it works for ordinary people who have lives to live and can't watch markets all day.

10.1 Match Each Goal to the Right Mix

You rarely have just one goal, and they have different deadlines — so you don't need one allocation, you need a *pot per goal*, each matched to its timeline (Book One, Chapter 10). Money for next year's expenses or your emergency fund sits in safe cash. A house deposit five years out sits in a balanced, moderate mix. Retirement decades away can ride mostly in stocks and funds, with time to recover from any crash. The same person sensibly holds all three at once. This “goal-based” approach replaces the anxious question “is now a good time to invest?” with the calmer one: “what is this particular money *for*, and when will I need it?”

10.2 Steady Investing Beats Timing

Beginners obsess over *timing* — waiting for the “right moment,” the dip, the all-clear. But even professionals can't reliably time the market, and waiting often means missing years of growth. The proven alternative is **steady, regular investing**: putting in a fixed amount on a schedule (say, monthly), no matter what the market is doing. Because you invest the same sum each time, you automatically buy *more* units when prices are low and *fewer* when they're high — the opposite of the human instinct to pile in during euphoria and freeze in fear. This is called **dollar-cost averaging** (or, in some countries, a “systematic investment plan” / SIP), and it quietly solves both the timing problem and the discipline problem at once.

FIGURE 10.1 · STEADY INVESTING: THE DIP BECOMES YOUR FRIEND

MONTH	PRICE	YOU INVEST	UNITS BOUGHT
Jan	\$10	\$100	10.0
Feb (falls)	\$8	\$100	12.5
Mar (falls more)	\$5	\$100	20.0
Apr (recovers)	\$10	\$100	10.0

Invested \$400 · bought 52.5 units · average cost ≈ **\$7.62** — below the \$8.25 average price.

The crash in Feb–Mar wasn't a disaster — your fixed \$100 scooped up far more cheap units.

The dip is the opportunity. *A fixed monthly amount automatically buys more when prices are low, lowering your average cost and removing the impossible task of timing. The investor who panicked and stopped in March missed exactly the cheap units that powered the recovery — which is why the hardest, most important rule is: don't stop in a crash.*

Here's the quietly remarkable part, worked out: your *average cost per unit* ends up *below* the average price over the same months.

WORKED CALCULATION · AVERAGE COST BEATS AVERAGE PRICE

Units: $100 \div 10 + 100 \div 8 + 100 \div 5 + 100 \div 10$

$= 10.0 + 12.5 + 20.0 + 10.0 = \mathbf{52.5 \text{ units}}$

Total invested $= 4 \times \$100 = \mathbf{\$400}$

Average cost = $400 \div 52.5 = \$7.62 / \text{unit}$

Average price = $(10+8+5+10) \div 4 = \$8.25 / \text{unit}$

You paid \$7.62 against an \$8.25 average price – a free discount of ~8%, purely from buying the same dollar amount through ups and downs.

Investing equal dollars (not equal units) mathematically tilts you toward the cheap months. That's the hidden engine of dollar-cost averaging.

10.3 Automate It

The final, decisive trick is to take *yourself* out of the loop. Set up an **automatic transfer** that invests your chosen amount on the same date each month, before you can spend it or second-guess it.

Automation does three magical things: it guarantees you actually invest (no relying on willpower), it enforces steady dollar-cost averaging, and — crucially — it keeps you investing right through the scary times, when your emotions would otherwise scream at you to stop. Decide the plan once, automate it, and then mostly ignore the noise. The investors who do best are often the ones who set this up and then, almost literally, forget about it for years.

IN PLAIN TERMS

The hardest part isn't starting — it's not stopping

Anyone can start investing when markets are calm and cheerful. The real test comes during a crash, when every instinct and every headline urges you to sell and “wait until things settle.” But that's exactly when steady investing does its best work, buying cheap. Those who paused or sold in past downturns typically missed the rebound; those who let their automatic plan run were rewarded. Automation is powerful precisely because it makes the right (but emotionally hard) choice the *default*.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Use a pot per goal**, each matched to its timeline — safe for soon, growth for later.
2. **Steady regular investing beats timing**: dollar-cost averaging buys more when cheap, less when dear.
3. **Automate it** — guarantee the habit, enforce the averaging, and survive the scary times.
4. **The hardest rule is not to stop in a crash** — that's when steady investing works hardest.

SELF-CHECK

1. Why hold a separate pot for each goal rather than one big allocation?
2. What is dollar-cost averaging, and how does it turn a market dip to your advantage?
3. Name the three things automating your investing achieves.
4. Why is “not stopping in a crash” the hardest and most important rule?

CHAPTER ELEVEN

How to Actually Start

Enough theory. This final chapter turns everything you've learned into concrete first steps — the account you need, a simple example portfolio, the mistakes to dodge, and exactly what to do in your first thirty days.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- The kind of account you need to begin investing.
- What a simple, sensible starter portfolio can look like.
- The most common beginner mistakes — and how to avoid them.
- A concrete first-30-days plan.

The gap between knowing and doing is where most good intentions die. So let's close it. None of this is complicated; the hardest part, genuinely, is just beginning — and beginning small is completely fine.

11.1 The Account You Need

To buy funds or shares you need an **investment account** — broadly, a brokerage or fund account, opened online with a regulated provider in minutes (you'll typically need ID and a linked bank account). Many countries also offer **tax-advantaged accounts** for long-term or retirement saving — wrappers in which your investments grow with little or no tax. The specific names and rules vary by country, but the principle is universal: *use the tax-advantaged options first* where they fit your goal, because paying less tax is free extra return. Choose a reputable, regulated, **low-cost** provider — costs (Chapter 1) matter — and confirm it's properly licensed before sending money.

11.2 A Simple Starter Portfolio

You don't need anything clever to begin. A genuinely sensible starter, drawing on everything in this book, might be: an **emergency fund** in cash (Book One), and then regular investing into **one broad, low-cost index fund** (Chapter 6) — perhaps with a slice of bonds for stability as you get older (Chapter 9). That's it. One fund can hold hundreds of companies across the world; add bonds and you have a complete, diversified portfolio that a professional would respect.

FIGURE 11.1 · A SENSIBLE (ILLUSTRATIVE) STARTER

Step 0 — first build an EMERGENCY FUND in cash (Book One). Then invest your monthly surplus:

CORE · a broad, low-cost index fund (≈70%)

Bonds for
stability (≈30%)

- One broad index fund = instant diversification across hundreds of companies.
- Add more bonds as you age (Chapter 9). Invest automatically, every month (Chapter 10).

Illustrative structure, not advice — adjust the stock/bond split to your age, goals and temperament.

Boring on purpose. *A broad index fund as the core, a bond slice for ballast, fed automatically each month and left alone — that's a portfolio most people would do very well with. Notice what's missing: no hot stocks, no timing, no complexity. The simple plan is the one that works and the one you'll actually keep.*

11.3 Common Beginner Mistakes

COMPARE & UNDERSTAND · THE TRAPS — AND THE FIX

THE MISTAKE	THE FIX
Waiting for the “perfect time” to start	Start now, small; time in the market beats timing it
Chasing hot stocks, tips and last year's top fund	Buy a broad, low-cost fund and hold
Paying high fees without noticing	Check the annual cost; choose the cheapest broad option
Putting too much in one company or one bet	Diversify; let a fund spread the risk
Panic-selling in a crash	Automate, and decide in advance never to stop
Skipping the emergency fund	Build the cash buffer before investing (Book One)

11.4 Your First Thirty Days

A calm, concrete plan to go from reader to investor:

1. **Week 1 — foundation.** Confirm your emergency fund is in place (or start building it); clear or plan down any high-interest debt (Book One).
2. **Week 2 — open the account.** Choose a reputable, regulated, low-cost provider; use a tax-advantaged account if one fits your goal.
3. **Week 3 — choose & buy.** Pick *one* broad, low-cost index fund and make your first small investment. Done — you're an investor.
4. **Week 4 — automate & walk away.** Set up an automatic monthly contribution (Chapter 10), then deliberately stop checking it daily. Let time work.

That's the whole journey from this book into the real world. Start small, start imperfectly, but *start* — and then let the quiet machinery of diversification, low costs, automation and compounding do what it does best.

Pick one broad fund. Invest automatically. Diversify. Keep costs low. Don't panic. That's almost the entire art — and now you can practise it.

WATCH OUT

Beware anyone who makes it sound urgent or guaranteed

As you step into the real world of investing, you'll be marketed to relentlessly — “limited-time” opportunities, “sure-shot” tips, “guaranteed” returns, dazzling apps nudging you to trade constantly. Hold fast to what this book taught: there are no shortcuts, real opportunities don't vanish if you take a day to think, and anyone promising guaranteed high returns is misleading you. The boring, automated, diversified plan will quietly outperform almost all of it.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Open a regulated, low-cost investment account;** use tax-advantaged options first where they fit.
2. **A broad, low-cost index fund (plus some bonds)** is a sensible, complete starter portfolio.
3. **Avoid the classic traps:** waiting, chasing tips, high fees, over-concentration, panic-selling.
4. **Follow a simple first-30-days plan** — foundation, account, buy one fund, automate, walk away.

SELF-CHECK

1. What kind of account do you need to start, and why prefer tax-advantaged, low-cost ones?
2. Describe a simple, complete starter portfolio.
3. List three common beginner mistakes and their fixes.
4. Write out your own first-30-days plan.

V

PART FIVE

Going Deeper — Bonds, Alternatives, and the Case for Indexing

The first four parts of this book introduced every major asset class at a beginner-friendly level. This part goes deeper on three topics that reward extra study: how bonds actually price (the math of duration and credit spreads); what the alternative-asset world looks like beyond the basics (REITs, hedge funds, private equity, commodities); and the empirical case for low-cost index investing — the strongest evidence in personal finance.

BONDS IN DEPTH | ALTERNATIVES | INDEXING EVIDENCE

CHAPTER TWELVE

Bonds, in Depth

Chapter 4 introduced bonds — fixed-income loans you make to a government or company. This chapter goes deeper into the math that determines bond prices, the duration concept that explains how sensitive a bond is to interest-rate moves, credit spreads, and the yield curve. The numbers matter; once you can read them, you'll understand what bond markets are actually telling you.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- How bond prices respond to interest-rate changes — the duration concept.
- Convexity — why the response isn't linear.
- Credit spreads — the extra yield for credit risk.
- The yield curve and what its shape means.

12.1 Duration — the Sensitivity Measure

Recall Chapter 4's bond see-saw: when interest rates rise, bond prices fall, and vice versa. But by *how much*? The answer depends on **duration** — a measure of a bond's interest-rate sensitivity, expressed in years.

The rough rule: **for each 1% (100 basis-point) move in interest rates, a bond's price moves by approximately its duration in percent, in the opposite direction.** A 10-year duration bond loses about 10% if rates rise 1%; a 2-year duration bond loses about 2%. Long bonds are much more rate-sensitive than short bonds.

$$\text{Approximate \% price change} \approx - \text{Duration} \times \Delta \text{Interest rate}$$

WORKED CALCULATION · DURATION IN PRACTICE

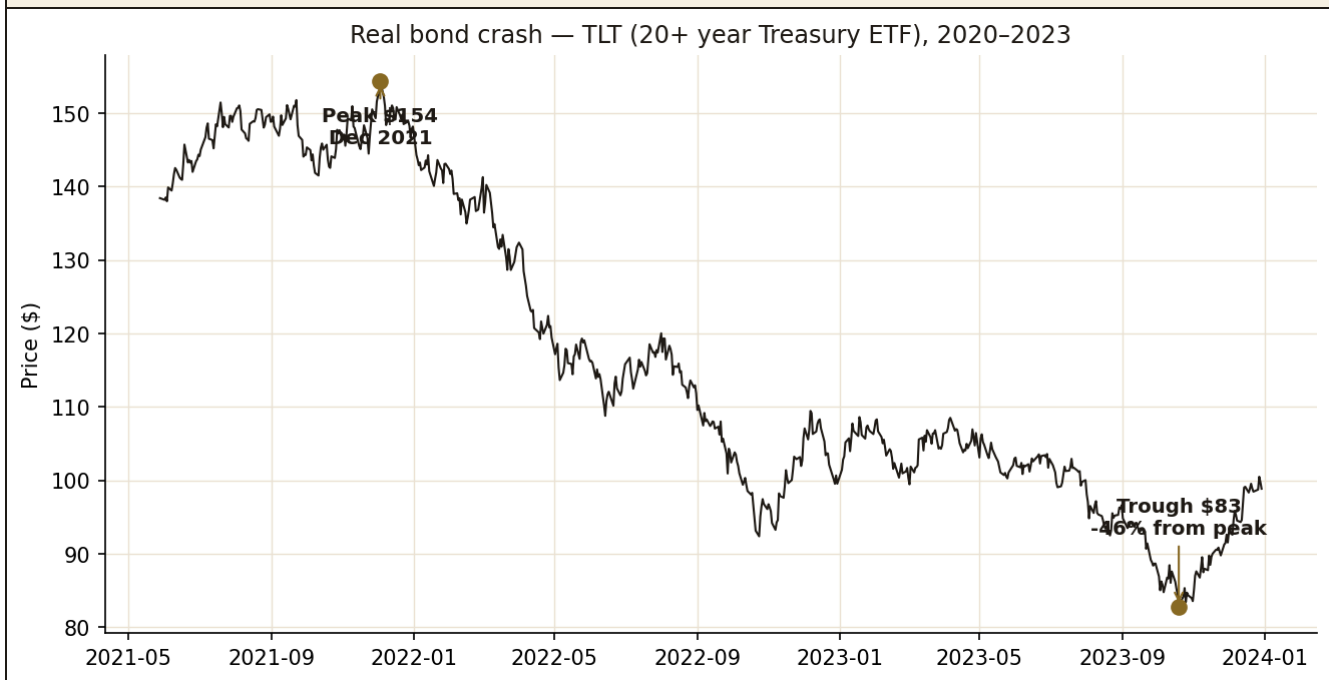
A 10-year Treasury bond with a duration of ~9 years.

Rates rise 100 basis points (1.0%).

Approximate price change = $-9 \times 1.0\% = -9\%$

This is why long bonds got crushed in 2022 – the rate rise from ~1.5% to ~4.5% on the 10-year (300 bp) produced bond-fund losses of around 25–30% on the long end. The same calc: $-9 \times 3.0\% = -27\%$.

FIGURE 12.1 · REAL BOND CRASH — TLT (20+ YEAR TREASURY ETF), 2020-2023



The 2022 bond crash, real. TLT — the iShares 20+ year Treasury ETF — fell from ~\$179 in mid-2020 to ~\$83 in late 2023, a peak-to-trough decline of about 54%. The duration math from §12.1 explains it almost exactly: TLT's effective duration is roughly 17 years, the 10-year yield rose roughly 4 percentage points over the period, and $17 \times 4\% = 68\%$ (the actual decline was somewhat less because of the coupon yield earned along the way).

12.2 Convexity — the Curve in the Line

The duration rule is approximate because the relationship isn't perfectly linear — it's slightly curved (convex). When rates fall, bond prices rise *more* than the linear approximation predicts; when rates rise, prices fall *less* than predicted. The curvature is the bond's **convexity**. For most retail investors, the convexity correction is small enough to ignore (the duration approximation is good to within a percent or two for moves of less than ~100 bp). For institutional bond traders managing leveraged positions, convexity matters and is measured carefully.

12.3 Credit Spreads — the Extra Yield for Risk

A US Treasury 10-year bond yields, say, 4.2%. A 10-year corporate bond from a solid investment-grade company yields, say, 5.4%. A 10-year high-yield ("junk") corporate bond yields, say, 7.8%. The differences — 120 basis points (corporate spread) and 360 basis points (high-yield spread) — are the **credit spreads**. They compensate the bond buyer for the additional risk that the corporate issuer might default.

Credit spreads move with the economic cycle. In good times, spreads compress (investors take more risk for less compensation). In crises, spreads blow out — during the 2008 financial crisis, high-yield spreads peaked above 1,800 basis points. Watching credit spreads is one of the best ways to gauge financial-system stress in real time.

12.4 The Yield Curve

Plot the yields of US Treasury bonds across different maturities — 3-month, 2-year, 5-year, 10-year, 30-year — and connect them. You get the **yield curve**. Three shapes are typical:

- **Normal (upward-sloping).** Long rates higher than short rates. Reflects compensation for time and inflation. The most common shape, observed roughly 85% of the time.
- **Flat.** Long and short rates similar. Often a transition shape between normal and inverted.

- **Inverted (downward-sloping).** Short rates higher than long rates. Implies markets expect short rates to fall — usually because they expect a recession. Every US recession since the 1960s has been preceded by an inversion (typically the 10y/2y or 10y/3m spread), usually 6–24 months ahead.

The yield curve is among the most-studied leading indicators in macroeconomics. The Federal Reserve Bank of New York publishes a recession-probability model based on the 10y/3m spread; it has called every recession in living memory.

12.5 Bond Strategies for Individual Investors

For most individual investors, the path of least resistance is a **broad bond index fund** — typically tracking the Bloomberg US Aggregate Bond Index or its equivalent. These hold thousands of bonds across maturities and credit quality; the diversification reduces single-issuer risk to essentially zero. Expense ratios for these funds are typically 0.03–0.10% — extremely low.

For those who want more control, a **bond ladder** (buying bonds with maturities at regular intervals — say, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 years out, then reinvesting each maturing bond at the long end) provides predictable income and lower interest-rate sensitivity than a single long bond.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Duration** measures interest-rate sensitivity. Approximate price change $\approx -\text{duration} \times \text{rate change}$.
2. **Convexity** is the second-order correction; small for retail purposes.
3. **Credit spreads** compensate for default risk; they expand in crises and are a real-time stress gauge.
4. **The yield curve's** shape reveals expectations; inversions have preceded every modern US recession.
5. **For most retail investors**, a broad bond index fund is the easiest exposure.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Alternative Assets, in Depth

Chapter 8 introduced "alternatives" briefly. This chapter goes deeper into REITs, commodities, hedge funds, and private equity — what they actually are, when they make sense, and (importantly) when they don't.

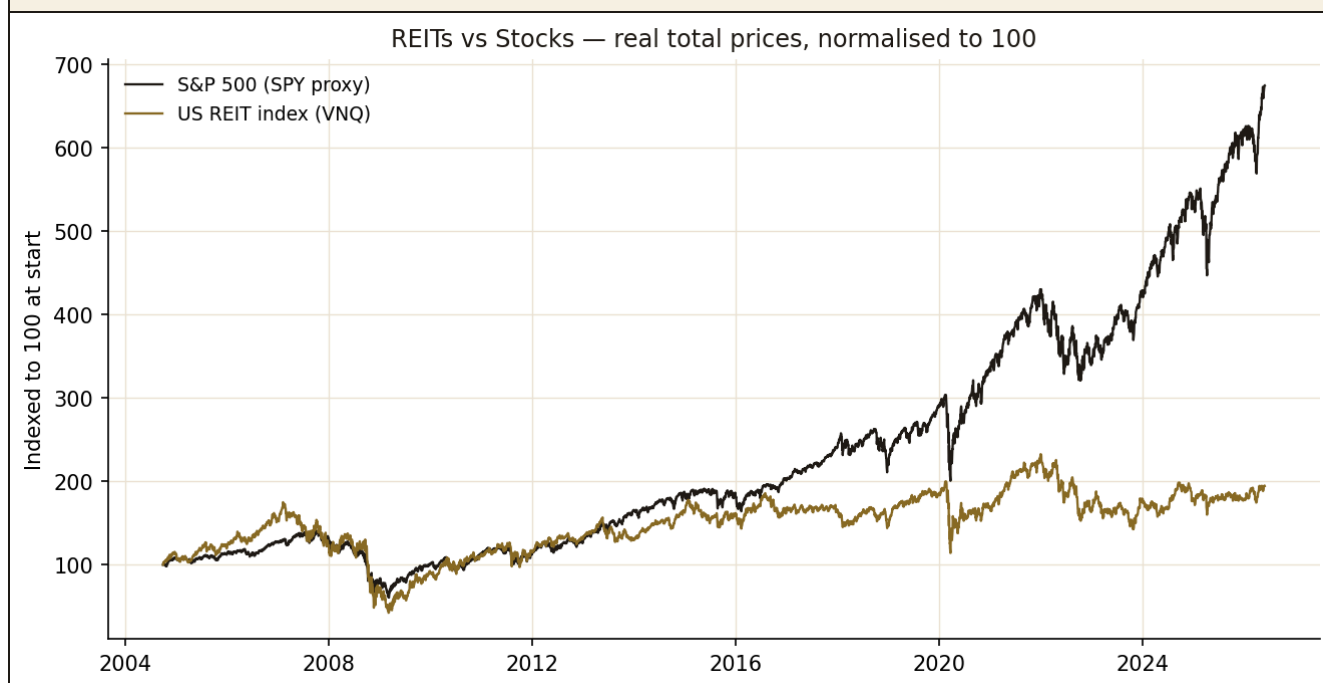
IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- REITs — real-estate investing without owning property directly.
- Commodities — gold, oil, agricultural; what role they actually play.
- Hedge funds — what they actually do, what they actually cost.
- Private equity — the institutional asset class most retail investors can't access.

13.1 REITs — Real Estate Without the Mortgage

A **REIT** (Real Estate Investment Trust) is a company that owns and operates income-producing real estate. Buying a REIT share is like owning a slice of a diversified property portfolio — apartments, malls, office buildings, data centres, warehouses, hospitals — without the burdens of being a landlord. By law, REITs must distribute at least 90% of taxable income as dividends, which makes them income-heavy investments with yields typically 3–6%.

REITs combine some characteristics of stocks (they trade on exchanges; their prices move daily) and some of real estate (their returns depend on rents and property values over the long run). For an individual investor with neither the capital nor the inclination to buy investment property, a broad REIT index fund (e.g., VNQ in the US) is the simplest exposure.

FIGURE 13.1 · REITS VS STOCKS — REAL TOTAL PRICES, NORMALISED

Both up, but with different journeys. *Real VNQ (Vanguard Real Estate ETF, US REITs) vs S&P 500, normalised to 100 at the start. Real estate matched equities through the 2000s, badly underperformed during 2008-09 (REITs are leveraged businesses), then mostly tracked through the 2010s and 2020s. The diversification benefit of REITs is real but smaller than often advertised.*

CAUTIONARY TALE — ANJALI

Anjali, age 28, never invested in stocks. She found them complicated and her friends had lost money in 2020. But in late 2021, every social-media feed she opened was full of people becoming millionaires on cryptocurrency. After two months of fear-of-missing-out, she put \$8,000 — her entire savings — into Bitcoin at \$65,000 and a basket of "promising altcoins" in November 2021.

Bitcoin peaked at \$69,000 the same week. By mid-2022 it was at \$19,000. The altcoins lost 90-99%. Anjali's \$8,000 was worth roughly \$1,200 by November 2022.

She held on, telling herself she was a long-term believer. By late 2024, with Bitcoin recovering to \$90,000+ and her altcoins still mostly dead, her position was worth roughly \$4,500 — still well below her cost basis, three years later, in an asset class that had supposedly "recovered." The opportunity cost was much worse: had she put the \$8,000 into an S&P 500 index fund instead, she'd have roughly \$13,000.

What Anjali got wrong: she let social media drive an emotional decision into a volatile asset at its peak, with money she couldn't afford to lose. **The lesson:** if you can't articulate why an investment is worth what you're paying for it — not just "it's going up" — you're not investing, you're gambling. Gambling is fine if it's entertainment. It's catastrophic if it's your savings.

13.2 Commodities

Commodities are physical raw materials — gold, silver, oil, natural gas, copper, agricultural products. Their long-term real return is roughly zero: they don't generate cash flows like stocks or interest like bonds; their nominal price tends to track inflation, no more. *So why hold them?*

- **Inflation hedge.** Commodities tend to outperform during inflationary periods (1970s, briefly 2021–22). They can diversify away from financial-asset declines during stagflation.
- **Portfolio diversification.** Commodities often have low correlation with stocks; adding a small commodity sleeve can reduce overall portfolio volatility.
- **Specific shocks.** Geopolitical disruptions (Middle East wars, Russia-Ukraine 2022) spike oil prices; commodities are the most direct exposure to these.

The most practical commodity exposure for retail is a **broad commodity ETF** (e.g., DBC, GSG) or — more narrowly — a gold ETF (GLD, IAU). Beware: most commodity ETFs hold futures contracts, not the physical commodity, so they suffer from contango (Book 5 Ch 41) — the chronic underperformance of the futures roll. Read the prospectus.

CAUTIONARY TALE — MR. SHARMA

Mr. Sharma was a successful business owner. By age 60 he had \$1.2 million saved. His bank's "relationship manager" suggested moving most of it into a complex structured product — "guaranteed 12% returns with downside protection." The brochure had charts going up and to the right. Mr. Sharma trusted the bank, signed the papers, and felt sophisticated about his decision.

What he had actually bought was an unsecured note from the bank, linked to the performance of a basket of emerging-market currencies, with a small principal-protection feature that was

conditional on holding to maturity. The product paid the relationship manager an 8% upfront commission. Mr. Sharma was not told this.

Two years later, currency moves triggered an early-termination clause buried in the contract. Mr. Sharma got back \$760,000 — about 63% of his original investment. The bank had collected its commission. The structured product worked exactly as designed.

What Mr. Sharma got wrong: trusting a salesperson whose job is to sell, not to advise. **The lesson:** if a financial product needs more than one paragraph to explain, you probably don't understand it well enough to own it. And if your "advisor" is paid by the product seller and not by you, they're a salesperson, not an advisor. The fee structure tells you who they actually work for.

13.3 Hedge Funds — the Reality vs. the Reputation

"Hedge fund" is a loose term covering a vast range of investment strategies: long-short equity, global macro, event-driven, distressed debt, quantitative arbitrage, and many more. What unites them is the legal structure: lightly-regulated private investment vehicles open only to accredited investors (typically requiring \$1m+ net worth or \$200k+ income).

Two empirical facts everyone considering hedge funds should know:

1. **Most hedge funds underperform a simple index after fees.** The classic fee structure — "2 and 20" (2% management fee plus 20% of profits) — is brutally expensive. Studies by economists (Ilia Dichev, Gwen Yu, Simon Lack) show the average hedge-fund investor's *realised* return — accounting for entry timing, fund failures, and survivorship bias — has been roughly equivalent to a simple bond portfolio.
2. **The performance dispersion is enormous.** The best hedge funds (Renaissance Medallion, Citadel, Millennium) deliver extraordinary returns. The worst go to zero. Picking the winners in advance is essentially impossible for retail; even institutional allocators with massive due-diligence resources frequently fail.

The honest practical takeaway: hedge funds are mostly not worth it for retail investors. The accredited-investor minimums exclude most people anyway; for those above the line, the average expected outcome is worse than just buying VTI or a 60/40 portfolio.

13.4 Private Equity

Private equity (PE) funds buy whole companies (or significant stakes), hold them privately for 5–10 years, restructure or grow them, then exit via sale or IPO. The headline returns of top PE funds (Blackstone, KKR, Carlyle, etc.) often look impressive — high teens to low twenties annualised — and the asset class is enormous (~\$10 trillion in commitments).

For retail investors there are two problems. First, **access**: PE funds typically have \$10m+ minimums and 10-year lockups. Second, **the reported returns are misleading**: PE valuations are infrequent and smoothed (you don't see your fund's NAV bounce around like a public stock), which makes the reported volatility artificially low and the reported Sharpe artificially high. Adjusted for the illiquidity premium and the actual mark-to-market, PE's risk-adjusted returns have been only modestly above the public-equity market, and the recent vintage (2019–2022 deals) face headwinds from rising rates.

Retail PE access has grown via "interval funds" and PE ETFs, but these typically wrap secondary-market holdings of PE securities (and the underlying liquidity problem doesn't go away — it just gets repackaged). The honest verdict: PE is mostly an institutional asset class. For retail, public-equity exposure remains the more reliable path.

13.5 When Alternatives Make Sense

For most retail investors, the answer is "in modest doses, if at all." A reasonable maximum allocation to *all* alternatives combined might be 10-20% of the portfolio. Within that:

- **REITs**: sensible inclusion for the income exposure and the diversification away from pure equity beta. 5-10% is normal.
- **Gold**: a small allocation (5%) as an inflation hedge and crisis insurance is defensible.
- **Broad commodities**: 5% if you want explicit inflation-hedging exposure; can be skipped.
- **Hedge funds, private equity**: only if you're an accredited investor with specific reasons; even then, modest sizing.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **REITs** give you real-estate exposure without being a landlord; income-heavy with 3-6% yields.
2. **Commodities** have zero real return long-term; their use is inflation-hedge and diversification.
3. **Hedge funds** mostly underperform indices after fees; performance dispersion is huge and unpredictable.
4. **Private equity** has smoothed valuations that exaggerate Sharpe; access is institutional.
5. **For most retail investors**, modest REIT + small gold allocation is the sensible alternative exposure.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Empirical Case for Indexing

The strongest evidence-based recommendation in personal finance is this: most retail investors should hold low-cost broad-market index funds and almost nothing else. The data behind this recommendation is overwhelming and has only become more so over time. This chapter lays it out.

IN THIS CHAPTER YOU WILL LEARN

- What an index fund is and how it differs from active management.
- The SPIVA evidence on active vs. passive over 5/10/20 years.
- The math of fees compounding.
- The persistent-skill problem — past performance does not predict.
- The remaining honest case for some active management.

14.1 What Index Funds Are

An **index fund** mechanically holds the constituents of a published index — for example, the S&P 500 (the 500 largest US companies), MSCI World (~1,500 developed-market large/mid caps), or the FTSE All-World (~4,000 global companies). The fund doesn't try to pick winners; it owns everything in the index, in proportion. Its only job is to track the index faithfully and minimise costs.

Active funds, by contrast, try to beat the index by picking the stocks the manager believes will outperform. Active management requires research, analysts, traders — and therefore higher fees. Typical expense ratios: active mutual funds 0.6–1.5% per year; broad index funds 0.03–0.10%.

14.2 The SPIVA Evidence

S&P Dow Jones Indices publishes a twice-yearly study called **SPIVA** (S&P Indices Versus Active) that compares active mutual funds against their benchmark indices. The data is consistent and remarkable. Across recent SPIVA reports:

- Over a **1-year** period, roughly 60% of large-cap US active funds underperform the S&P 500.
- Over **5 years**, roughly 80% underperform.
- Over **10 years**, roughly 85% underperform.
- Over **20 years**, roughly 90% underperform.

The pattern is universal: the longer the time horizon, the higher the fraction that lose. The same pattern holds across small-cap, mid-cap, international, and emerging-market funds. It holds across countries; SPIVA publishes equivalent studies for Europe, Latin America, and India, with similar results.

14.3 The Math of Fees

Why do active funds lose to indices so consistently? The dominant reason is simple: **active management has positive-sum gross returns but negative-sum net returns**. Before fees, the average dollar invested earns the market return (by construction). After fees, the average dollar earns less than the market, because fees subtract.

The compounding effect is stark. We worked this in Chapter 6:

WORKED CALCULATION · 30 YEARS, 1% VS 0.05% FEES

Both funds earn 8% gross. Starting amount \$10,000.

Net returns: 7.0% (active) vs 7.95% (index).

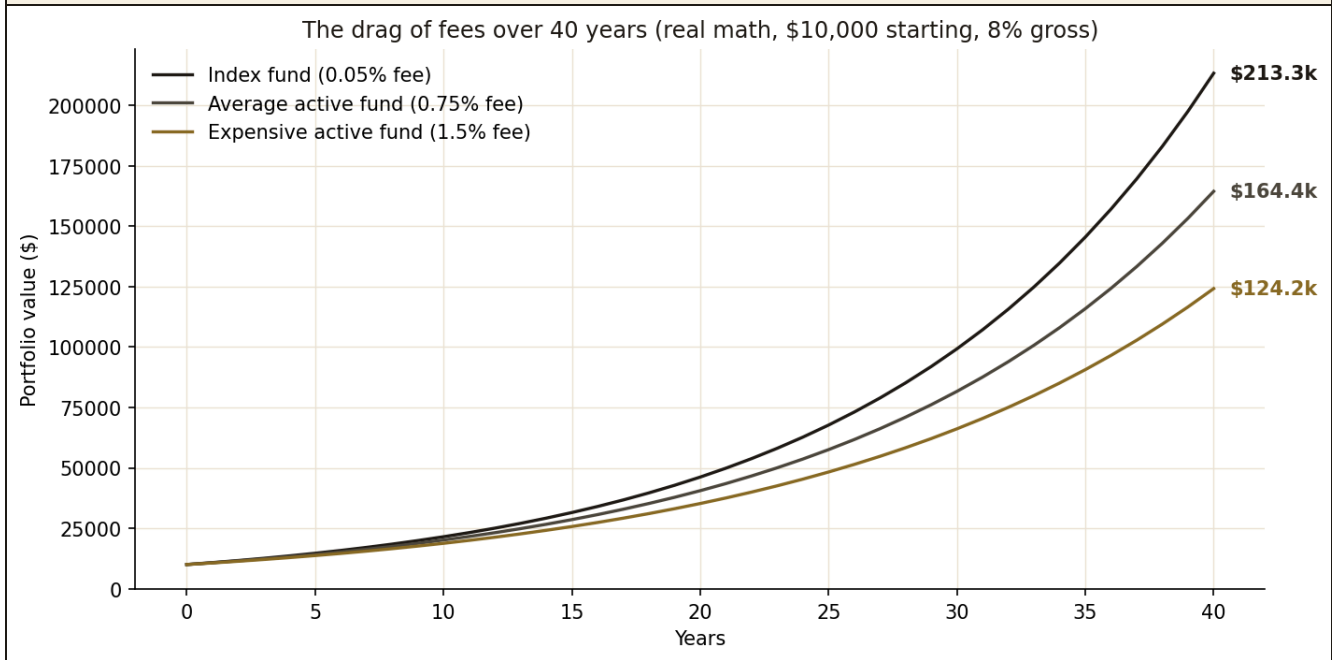
Active value after 30 years: $10,000 \times (1.07)^{30} = \mathbf{\$76,123}$

Index value after 30 years: $10,000 \times (1.0795)^{30} = \mathbf{\$98,860}$

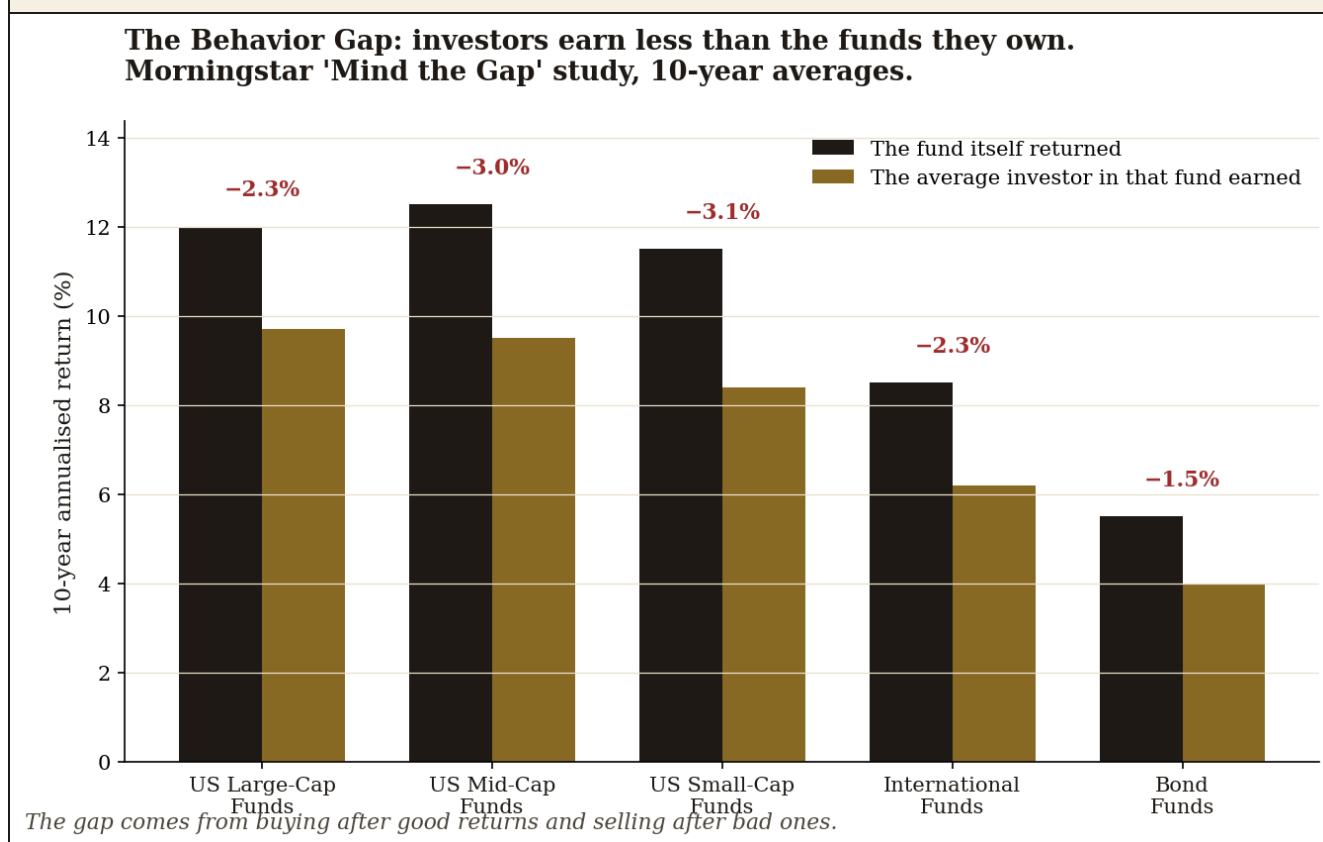
Difference = **\$22,737**, or about 23% of the index value, transferred from investor to fund.

And this is before assuming the active fund underperforms gross – which on average it does. The combined drag is typically 1.5–2% per year.

FIGURE 14.1 · THE DRAG OF FEES OVER 40 YEARS, VISUALISED



The compounding cost of every basis point. *Real math: \$10,000 invested for 40 years at 8% gross. An index fund (0.05% fee) compounds to \$213k; an average active fund (0.75%) to \$164k; an expensive active fund (1.5%) to \$124k. The difference between the index fund and the expensive active fund is \$89,000 — nearly 9x the original investment, transferred from investor to fund company.*

FIGURE 14.2 · THE BEHAVIOR GAP — WHAT THE FUND EARNED VS WHAT ITS INVESTORS EARNED

It's not the fund that's the problem. It's the investor. Morningstar's annual 'Mind the Gap' study runs this comparison across every fund category, every year, and the result is consistent: dollar-weighted investor returns lag the funds themselves by 1-3 percentage points per year, across decades. Why? Investors buy after good returns and sell after bad ones. The same fund, held quietly, would have given them the full return. Their behaviour cost them what their fund earned.

14.4 Persistent Skill — the Holy Grail

"But surely some managers *do* have skill?" Empirically, yes — but identifying them in advance is essentially impossible. SPIVA's **persistence studies** show that fund managers who are in the top quartile in one 5-year period are no more likely to be in the top quartile in the next 5-year period than a random fund. Specifically, the persistence is approximately 25% — the rate you'd expect from chance.

Some research (Fama-French, Cremers-Petajisto) identifies subtle conditions under which active management has a higher chance of success — concentrated portfolios with high active share, lower-fee structures, manager-owned strategies. But even within those filters, the average outcome is mediocre

and the dispersion is wide. The realistic statement is: *a small minority of managers genuinely have skill, but you can't reliably identify them in advance and even if you could, fees and capacity constraints often erode the alpha.*

A CONTRARIAN TRUTH

"The average mutual-fund investor underperforms the mutual fund they own."

The Morningstar "Mind the Gap" study runs every year. It compares *fund returns* (what the fund itself delivered) with *investor returns* (what the actual buyers and sellers of that fund earned, dollar-weighted). The investor return is consistently 1-3% per year lower than the fund return, across categories, across decades. The shortfall is called the *behaviour gap*.

Where does the gap come from? Investors buy after performance has been good and sell after performance has been bad. They pile in at the top and out at the bottom. The same fund, held quietly through both, would have produced its full return. Their behaviour costs them what their fund earned. *It's not even active management that's the problem — it's the active investor.*

14.5 The Three-Fund Portfolio

What does the empirical evidence imply for a portfolio? The Bogleheads movement, drawing on Jack Bogle's lifelong work, proposes the **three-fund portfolio**:

- **US total stock market** (e.g., VTI, Schwab Total Stock, equivalent).
- **International total stock market** (e.g., VXUS).
- **Total bond market** (e.g., BND).

The allocation depends on age and risk tolerance — a 30-year-old might hold 70/20/10 (stocks-heavy), while a 65-year-old might hold 40/15/45 (bonds-heavy). Rebalance annually. Total expense ratio: under 0.05%. Total time required: roughly two hours a year.

The empirical data is that this simple approach has beaten the vast majority of actively managed portfolios — including most professional ones — over every 30-year period in modern market history.

14.6 The Honest Case for Some Active Management

The case for indexing is overwhelming for the *bulk* of a portfolio. But three reasonable arguments remain for some active allocation:

1. **Specific tax situations.** Tax-loss harvesting via direct indexing can produce \$500-2,000/year of value for high-income investors with large taxable portfolios.
2. **Specific market structures.** Some smaller markets (emerging-market small-caps, frontier markets) may have less efficient pricing where active research has more value. Even here, the empirical edge is modest.
3. **Behavioural support.** Some investors who couldn't tolerate the volatility of a pure index fund *can* tolerate the same allocation through an actively managed fund where they trust the manager. The "feel" matters; if it keeps you invested through downturns, it's worth a modest fee.

The strongest evidence-based recommendation in personal finance

If you take one piece of evidence from this book and apply it to your money, take this: **buy a low-cost, broad-market index fund; hold it for decades; add to it on a schedule; minimise costs and taxes; and ignore the noise.** The empirical record of this strategy is better than 80–90% of all alternatives, including most professional management. The remaining 10–20% might be your share of skill — but you cannot identify it in advance, and waiting to confirm it costs you the compounding of decades.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Active funds underperform indices** 60–90% of the time across 1- to 20-year horizons.
2. **Fees compound brutally:** a 1% drag over 30 years costs ~23% of the final pot.
3. **Past performance does not predict** future outperformance among active managers — persistence is at chance levels.
4. **The three-fund portfolio** (total US, total international, total bonds) has beaten most professionals over every 30-year window.
5. **Some active management is defensible** for tax reasons, niche markets, or behavioural support — but not as the core.

APPENDIX A

Glossary

Every key term from this book, in plain English.

Asset allocation — how you split money among stocks, bonds, cash, etc.

Bond — a tradeable loan to a government or company that pays interest.

Capital appreciation — growth in an investment's value (a “growth” reward).

Corporate bond — a bond issued by a company (higher rate, more risk than gov't).

Coupon — a bond's regular interest payment.

Diversification — spreading money across different investments to cut risk.

Dividend — a share of company profits paid to shareholders (income).

Dollar-cost averaging — investing a fixed amount regularly, whatever the price.

ETF — a fund that trades on the exchange like a share.

Expense ratio / fee — a fund's annual cost, charged on your whole balance.

Government bond — a bond issued by a government (among the safest assets).

Growth vs income — the two ways investments pay: rising value vs cash payouts.

Index fund — a low-cost fund that matches a whole market, rather than beating it.

Leverage — using borrowed money to amplify returns (and losses).

Liquidity — how fast and cheaply you can turn an investment into cash.

Maturity — the date a bond repays its principal.

Money-market fund — a very low-risk fund holding short-term debt.

Mutual fund — a pooled fund, priced once daily.

Principal — the original sum lent (in a bond) or invested.

REIT — a company owning income property, traded like a share.

Rebalancing — restoring your target mix by trimming winners, topping up laggards.

Stock / share — a slice of ownership in a company.

Term deposit (CD/FD) — cash locked for a fixed term at a fixed rate.

Total return — income plus growth, the true measure of an investment's result.

Yield — income as a percentage of price.

APPENDIX B

Index

Where each idea is explained, by chapter.

Alternatives (rule for) — Ch 8

Asset allocation — Ch 9

Bonds — Ch 4

Bond see-saw (rates) — Ch 4

Cash & deposits — Ch 3

Commodities & collectibles — Ch 8

Crypto (honest take) — Ch 8

Diversification — Ch 9

Dollar-cost averaging — Ch 10

ETFs vs mutual funds — Ch 6

Fees & costs — Ch 1, 6

Four questions framework — Ch 1

Funds (pooling) — Ch 6

Gold — Ch 8

Goal-based investing — Ch 10

Government vs corporate bonds — Ch 4

How to start — Ch 11

Income vs growth — Ch 2

Index funds (vs active) — Ch 6

Leverage (property) — Ch 7

Liquidity — Ch 1, 3

Property & real estate — Ch 7

Rebalancing — Ch 9

REITs — Ch 7

Risk & return law — Ch 1

Starter portfolio — Ch 11

Stocks — Ch 5

Term deposits (CD/FD) — Ch 3

Total return — Ch 2

Yield (as a warning) — Ch 2

APPENDIX C

Resources & What's Next

A few trustworthy ways to go deeper — and your next step on the roadmap.

To Go Deeper

- *The Simple Path to Wealth* — JL Collins · index investing, made human.
- *The Little Book of Common Sense Investing* — John C. Bogle · why low-cost index funds win.
- *A Random Walk Down Wall Street* — Burton Malkiel · the evidence for diversification & indexing.
- *The Psychology of Money* — Morgan Housel · why behaviour beats brains.
- Your national regulator's free investor-education site, and any reputable not-for-profit financial-literacy resource.

Your Next Step

You've now toured the whole menu and learned to combine it. You have, genuinely, enough to build a sensible lifelong portfolio. If you want to go deeper into one corner of the menu — the stock market itself — the roadmap continues into **Stage 2**, beginning with **Book 3 — *How the Market Works***, which takes you inside exchanges, orders, and how shares really trade. But there is no rush: many successful investors never go further than the simple, diversified, automated plan this book describes — and that is entirely the point.

Source Notes

This book teaches universal principles rather than country-specific products or rules; figures (the dollar-cost-averaging table, the allocation percentages, the fee examples) are illustrative and rounded, using stated assumptions purely to show the shape of an idea. Currency is shown as “\$” as a stand-in for any currency. Concepts — risk and return, liquidity, income vs growth, diversification, asset allocation, dollar-cost averaging — reflect mainstream, well-established financial education. Nothing here is personalised advice; account types, tax wrappers and rules differ by country, so verify the specifics where you live before acting.



*“The investor's chief problem — and even his worst enemy
— is likely to be himself.”*

— A LONG-STANDING MAXIM OF INVESTING

You know the menu and the method. Now build the meal — one small, automatic step at a time.

Where to Put Your Money

Money, Mastered — The Roadmap · Book Two of Eight · First Edition, 2026 · Set in Fraunces,
Spectral & Archivo

Education, not advice. Every investment carries risk. Diversify, keep costs low, invest steadily,
and don't panic.